

Bangladesh-Myanmar Relations Regarding the Rohingya Refugee Crisis

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Facing decades of systemic persecution and rejection by society, and horrific atrocities at the hands of the Burmese government, the Rohingya people are forced to endure what is widely considered to be one of the worst humanitarian crises in the 21st century. Each passing year has been progressively worse for these Rohingyas as Myanmar enacts harsher and more brutal measure to eradicate their identity and existence. As of date, about 1.2 million Rohingyas have become refugees or asylum-seekers, while six hundred thousand of whom are left stateless, according to a data gathered by the UN Refugee Agency (UNHCR, 2022). While some refugees make their way into nearby countries, like Malaysia, India and Thailand, most of them seek refuge in Bangladesh as it is the closest country and the one that has been relatively more willing to accept them. However, the prolonged crisis has put Bangladesh to the limit as they can only help so many refugees due to increasing social and economic constraints, from providing enough shelters for the refugees to allocating enough food and money to help sustain their well-being. As a result, a growing resentment from this South Asian country towards the Rohingya refugees emerges. At the same time, the relationship between Bangladesh and Myanmar are at an all-time low, due to the latter's inability to stop the crisis which they had started in the first place, and their unwillingness to cooperate or have positive diplomatic negotiations with the former, which only exacerbates this ill feeling towards one another.

The root of this refugee crisis lies in the ethnic and religious violence between the Rohingya Muslims and the Rakhine Buddhists. Both groups live in the state of Rakhine (formerly known as Arakan) and make up the majority of its population of 3.8 million; the

Buddhists account for 59.7% of the population and Muslims (including Rohingyas, as well as Bengali and Arab minorities) account for the other 35.6% (Mohajan, 2018, p. 2). The origins of these peoples remain a huge controversy to this day. It is commonly believed that the Rohingya people trace their ancestry to Arab merchants settling in the region three centuries ago (Mohajan, 2018, p. 9). Another author, Salman Sohel, asserts that the Rohingyas could be the living remnants of the once prosperous Muslim kingdom of Mrauk-U, which lasted from 1430 until 1785 when it was conquered by the Burmese king, and that the region of Arakan used to be predominantly Muslim; he adds, even the term Rohingya may come from the terms ‘Rohan’ or ‘Rosham’, which were old names for Arakan (Sohel, 2017, pp. 1007–1008). On the other hand, both the Myanmar government and various Burmese historians claim that these people are all Bengali Muslims coming from Bangladesh as migrant laborers during the British colonial era and as immigrants who have been coming in over recent years (Mohajan, 2018, p. 12). The dispute centers around whether or not the Rohingyas are natives to the state of Rakhine in which the Burmese authority conveniently weaponizes their own claim regarding this to justify their persecution and expulsion of these people.

Myanmar’s hostile attitude towards Rohingya people is one symptom of their general fear of Muslims. Their close proximity to Bangladesh, which is a Muslim country and has a population three times the size of Myanmar’s at 170 million, only adds more fuel to this paranoia. The hate towards Muslims became prominent during the British colonial period in the 19th century as the British imposed policies that heavily favored Muslims more than Buddhists, such as the appointment of only Muslims to various administrative positions due to the Buddhists’ general anti-British sentiment (Rohingya Culture Center, 2022). Later in the Second World War, there was another fight between the Muslims and Buddhists as the former sided with

Britain and the latter welcomed the Japanese troops as liberators, resulting in a series of massacres in 1942 where up to 40,000 or more people were killed in these communal riots (Leider, 2020, pp. 2–3). As Myanmar became independent, a new sense of nationalism began to grow, and with it, Buddhist radicalism. In 1999, an extremist Buddhist organization, known as the 969 Movement, entered the stage, advocating for the complete removal of Muslim presence and protection of Myanmar from a possible Muslim takeover or “Islamization” of the country; with its leader, Ashin Wirathu, the group has been responsible for carrying out many deadly attacks against Rohingya Muslim civilians (Sohel, 2017, pp. 1012–1013). Burmese ultranationalism combined with Buddhist extremism and Islamophobia, have further marginalized the Muslim minority away from their own society that they live in.

Following its independence from the British, the socio-political situation in Myanmar has been as volatile as ever before, with civil wars and insurgencies springing up across the country. The coup d'état in 1962 effectively ensured the Tatmadaw's (Burma's military) control over the country, leaving the fate of Rohingya people at their hands. Under the supervision of the dictator Ne Win, the Citizenship Law of 1982 made sure that Rohingya people would never be considered as neither one of the ethnic groups in Myanmar nor citizens of the country, and in 1978, the first government-approved purge, known as Operation Dragon King, took place, which left almost tens of thousands of Muslims dead and a few hundreds of thousands displaced (Parnini, 2013, pp. 285–286). Just less than a decade ago, the Burmese government banned the use of the term ‘Rohingya’ and would refer to these people as Bengalis in the national population census of 2014 (BBC, 2014). Fundamentally, Myanmar no longer sees Rohingyas as one of their own and denies the entirety of their identity and culture. By grouping these people with the Bengalis in Bangladesh, the Myanmar government achieves a deepening divide in the two

countries' relations because now, Naypyidaw could shift the blame of this conflict to Dhaka, and it further reinforces Burmese people's negative perception of Bengalis in general.

Despite this tension, Myanmar and Bangladesh have never gone into any major conflict against one another before, other than minor border skirmishes with very few to no casualties. There have been several incidents that cause some strains in their relations. For instance, in late 1991, during another attempt to purge Rohingya resistance and expel their people (known as Operation Clean and Beautiful Nation), the Burmese troops came into contact with the Bangladeshi patrols as they crossed into Bangladesh's territory. There was another standoff between the two side's navy due to the dispute over who would obtain more control over the northeastern part of the Bengal Bay following the discovery of natural gas in the area (The Guardian, 2008). There were several more incidents where Myanmar's troops fired shots and killed Bangladeshi fishermen (Ahamed et al., 2020, p. 350). These events may cause irritants for both governments, but were completely overshadowed by the Rohingya conflicts and refugee crisis, which sit right on their borders and present both security and economic issues for the two nations.

Myanmar's ethnic cleansing policies have left huge scars for Rohingya people who have been living in the Arakan region for centuries. This is where the concepts of forced migration and return migration come into play. The Operation Dragon King in 1978 was especially devastating as Rohingya communities were burned and destroyed, and thousands were subjected to torture, rape, executions and imprisonment, which left more than 200,000 people to be displaced—the majority of whom escaped to Bangladesh (Sohel, 2017, p. 1014). Another wave of a quarter of a million refugees went to Bangladesh in the early 1990s. Moving forward to 2012, a series of ethnic and religious clashes between the Rohingyas and Rakhine happened

again, leading to over a thousand deaths and another 140,000 Muslim civilians internally displaced (Sohel, 2017, p. 1015). Thus far, there had been very little international attention to this crisis. It was not until 2016 when the UN started to look into serious allegations of a genocide going on (Smith, 2016). Just two years later, approximately 25,000 civilians were slaughtered by the Burmese authority and 700,000 others crossed the border into Bangladesh (Ellis-Peterson, 2018). When put into perspective, these are extremely alarming figures. Despite Myanmar's major political reforms and transition into a democracy in 2016, the Rohingya crisis kept going worse and worse. It is ironic that the pro-democracy champion and Nobel Peace Prize winner, Aung San Suu Kyi, who was held with high respect by the international community and became Myanmar's first female president, turned a blind eye towards the Rohingyas' plight for mercy, as she was more concerned with garnering support from the Buddhist majority. Myanmar, regardless of being authoritarian or democratic, has still remained essentially an apartheid state where Rohingya Muslims were seen as not one of their own, but belonged to foreign lands—in particular, Bangladesh.

Receiving these many refugees while maintaining a secure border with Myanmar are no easy tasks for Bangladesh. As of late, a total of more than 900,000 refugees are now in the country, according to the UN, but the official data given out by the Dhaka government puts it at 1.1 million (Ansar et al., 2021, pp. 2–3). The Bangladeshi government delegated the port city of Cox's Bazar, which is located in the southeastern part of the country, as the main hub for hosting refugees. It is estimated that around \$1.2 billion have been provided to the Rohingya refugees each year by Bangladesh; even the locals of this hosting country express generally positive and sympathetic feelings towards the refugees, from providing shelter, to giving food and money, although this can be attributed to the shared religion and cultures, and similar hardships that both

the Bengalis and Rohingyas have gone through (Rahman, 2022). Compared to other countries in Myanmar, Bangladesh has so far shown its great willingness to provide aids to the Rohingyas, despite being a very poor country itself. Nonetheless, it is only a matter of time before Bangladesh cannot afford sustaining the refugees, given that the crisis is nowhere near resolution.

Due to the massive influx of asylum-seekers since 2017, the refugee camps quickly became overwhelmed. Based on an account of a Norwegian humanitarian assistance team (NORCAP) sent to help these refugees, the condition of the settlements was abysmal as they were overcrowded, and now prone to heavy storms, floods and landslides (Kolstad, 2018). In 2021, the UN Refugee Agency reports that a large portion of the refugee camps was hit by a fire that burned down almost 10,000 homes, leaving 11 people killed, and later that year, there was a huge storm, that caused flooding and landslides in the area, forcing some 24,000 people out of their temporary shelters (Yeasmine, 2021). Furthermore, it is known that Bangladesh has one of the highest population densities in the planet, which makes it even more difficult for Bangladesh to find enough space for the already high number of refugees present. With so many people cramped in such small areas, access to sanitation and comfort would be very minimal. Especially over the last couple of years when the COVID-19 pandemic was in full swing, the threat of this virus spreading throughout the community is very high. The exact number of refugees who got infected is unknown as there was little testing being done and the health care assistance was insufficient. However, there had been aids from international NGOs, like the UN, which provided vaccinations to over 34,000 people as of late 2021 (Yeasmine, 2021). In addition, Rohingya refugees have to deal with the high rate of crime in the community, such as rape and murder. Not less than a month ago as of this year, there was a terrorist attack by the Arakan

Rohingya Salvation Army (ARSA), which killed seven people; these attackers were said to target any Rohingya who is working to repatriate people back to Myanmar (Ripon, 2022). The result is that there was a crackdown on many Rohingyas who were suspected to be associated with this militant group, and the Bangladeshi authority reports that most of the crimes were committed by the ARSA who infiltrated into the camps. Even after successfully escaping into Bangladesh from Burmese persecution, Rohingya people, especially women and children, still have a very tough time ahead of them to get used to their new place and to overcome the various challenges as listed above.

Bangladesh's ability and capacity to sustain millions of refugees are stretching thinner by the day. The crisis may hurt the Dhaka government as they are spending billions of dollars to stop it, but the local Bangladeshis are much more deeply impacted, especially in terms of the shifts in the local economy. The Rohingya refugees could not sustain themselves by solely relying on outside aids, so they must compete for low-skilled jobs with the locals. According to one survey, the daily wage of a laborer has dropped by half from what generally used to be \$7 a day to around \$3 a day; among the most affected groups are fishermen (Ansar et al., 2021, p. 6). Taking into consideration of the refugees, as well as the thousands of aid workers living in the area, the authors find that there has been a staggering increase in housing prices, with rents going up by over 120%, and also a rise in prices of common household products (Ansar et al., 2021, p. 7). One article earlier this year shows that tourism has greatly decreased in Cox's Bazar mainly due to security concerns over rape cases and the increasing commodity prices (Hossain, 2022). Consequently, the region's economy has been hit extremely hard and the host communities begin to show resentment towards the refugees. Despite the deep bonds between the locals and the Rohingyas, these strains and limitations are pushing towards a whole new ethnic tension.

The Bangladeshi government has tried to solve the crisis both at its border and back home, but the result has not been enough. The authorities made a couple attempts to repatriate the Rohingyas back to Myanmar between 2018 and 2019, but the missions were largely a failure because the situation in Myanmar was simply not suitable for the refugees to return yet (Rahman, 2022). It is said that Dhaka plans to relieve some of the burden on Cox's Bazar by moving some 100,000 refugees to a small island off the coast of Chittagong, known as Bhasan Char. This plan, also called the Ashrayan Project, costs around \$224 million and seeks to settle in 100,000 Rohingya refugees by building new homes, various critical infrastructures, and other amenities (Khokon, 2017). In February of 2022, more than 22,000 refugees have been successfully relocated there (Rahman, 2022). However, this plan has been met with criticisms as the Bangladeshi government is trying to forcefully move refugees around without their consent. In particular, because the island is vulnerable to natural disasters, new concerns have been made about the safety of the refugees and whether or not Dhaka actually tries to protect them. While great efforts have been made to mitigate the problems, Bangladesh's resources have been strained significantly. In essence, the biggest victims to this whole conflict are both the Rohingya refugees and the local host communities.

On Myanmar's side, little has been done to cease the violence and refugee crisis. In January of 2021, the previous regime under Aung San Suu Kyi eventually opened up to negotiations with Bangladesh for the repatriation of some 42,000 Rohingya people, thanks to Beijing's interference (Mostofa, 2022). However, the entire process came to an abrupt halt following a coup d'état by the Burmese military led by Min Aung Hlaing. The new junta regime immediately saw the widespread insurrections across Myanmar, particularly in the state of Rakhine. Because the conflict has been happening very close to the Bangladeshi border, it is

reported that the Burmese military has violated Bangladesh's territory on many occasions—there were accounts of mortar shells fired into Bangladesh and Burmese helicopters entering its airspace (Charulata, 2022). Despite Naypyidaw insisting they have no intention of attacking its western neighbor, it has failed to ensure peace and safety along the border. The political instability in Myanmar, along with the prospect of a new massive wave of refugees due to the war, pose a serious threat to Bangladesh.

The relationship between the two countries, given these burden and grievances, and the hostility towards one another, are expected to reach a new boiling point sometime in the future, if no action is taken to ease the situation. As of writing, the socio-political condition in this region still maintains its status-quo. The civil wars have devastated Myanmar and its population. While there is absolute order in Naypyidaw under the Tatmadaw's authoritarian control, there is anarchy in the provinces. The hatred between the Buddhists and Muslims, and the racism between the Rohingyas and Burmese will never go away in the foreseeable future due to how deeply rooted it is. Burmese ultranationalism combined with Buddhist radicalism and extreme Islamophobia, have made the Rohingya Muslims the prime targets of human rights abuses. While there were negotiations between Bangladesh and Myanmar to resolve the conflicts, almost all of them are futile. There have been international commitment to help end the crisis, such as in the case of the UN which condemns Myanmar's persecution of Rohingyas and sends food and supplies to the refugees. Some Southeast Asian countries, like Malaysia and Indonesia, have made a similar condemnation on the Burmese but could not do anything more thanks to the limitations imposed upon all ASEAN countries not to interfere in each other's domestic affairs. A few big countries in the region, like China, have tried mediating peace talks, but as said before, the political instability in Myanmar makes it almost impossible for any new reform to be

enforced effectively. China has a lot of influence in both Myanmar and Bangladesh due to trade and investment, but its constant backing of Min's authoritarian regime does not help the case at all. Even mainstream media attention for the Rohingya refugee crisis has decreased due to other major conflicts happening elsewhere in the world. There needs to be more international pressure to help end the civil conflicts in Myanmar and allow it to make reasonable reforms so that everyone, especially the Rohingyas, could finally achieve peace and safety in their country.

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